The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Israel continued attacking **Gaza** as the holy month of Ramadan began. The **Israel Defence Forces** reportedly struck a site on Saturday where Marwan Issa—a leader of the Qassam Brigades, Hamas's armed wing—may have been hiding, and is trying to confirm whether he was killed. Meanwhile, the departure of the first ship carrying humanitarian aid from Cyprus to Gaza was delayed.

President Joe Biden proposed a $7.3trn budget for the coming fiscal year. The plan proposes lower costs of child care and housing, among other things. That would be funded by higher taxes on corporations and the rich. But Mr Biden's proposal will likely not pass the House of Representatives, which is controlled by Republicans.

The annual meeting of China's parliament, the **National People's Congress**, concluded. Delegates rubber-stamped new policies, including on the economy. Those will do little to placate investors or citizens: the newly-set target of around 5% GDP growth for 2024 will not easily be met. Regardless, Xi Jinping, the country's president, used the event to demonstrate his absolute power.

Following his visit to Mar-a-Lago last week, **Viktor Orban**, Hungary's autocratic prime minister, told Hungarian state media that, as president, **Donald Trump** would "not give a single penny" in support of Ukraine "therefore the war will end". Mr Trump's wing of the Republican party is increasingly resistant to funding Ukraine, as is Mr Orban, who until last month held up European efforts to send more aid.

The price of **bitcoin** exceeded $71,000, an all-time high. The cryptocurrency has rallied for five consecutive days and gained more than 60% since the start of the year. The surge has been driven by a wave of capital flowing into newly-approved bitcoin exchange-trading funds. British regulators said on Monday that they would allow the creation of similar crypto-related securities.

India implemented the Citizenship Amendment Act, a controversial law which initially passed in 2019, weeks before a general election. It allows immigrants from three countries—Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan—quicker access to citizenship. But while it accepts adherents of six religions from those countries, it does not include Muslims. That challenges the secularism enshrined in India's constitution and advances the government's Hindu-nationalist priorities.

Britain's Office for National Statistics added **vinyl records** to the inflation basket, which is intended to reflect consumers's spending habits. Records were taken out of the basket in 1992, but have become more popular in Britain in recent years. Other additions include air fryers and edible sunflower seeds. Hand sanitizers and hot rotisserie cooked chicken were removed.

Fact of the day: Two**,** the number of third-party candidates that have taken more than 5% of the national vote in America's presidential election in the past 50 years. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox

Photo: AP

Biden’s budget day

America’s Congress is still haggling over this year’s budget. But negotiations are about to begin on next year’s. On Monday Joe Biden released his plan for the coming fiscal year. The president’s blueprint—a $7.3trn proposal meant, in part, to make childcare and housing cheaper—has no chance of becoming law because Republicans control the House of Representatives. But the budget is an opportunity for him to say what his priorities are ahead of the presidential election.

He is likely to propose a refreshed version of Bidenomics. The plan may feature increased spending on health insurance for the elderly, on tax credits for young families and on preschools. To pay for all this, Mr Biden will call for higher taxes on corporations and the rich. Republicans will call it a reckless tax-and-spend budget; Mr Biden will deem it essential to the country’s future. Fiscal policy may not be top of mind for most voters. But those who care will have two starkly different visions to choose between in November.

Chaos reigns in Haiti

On Monday Caribbean leaders are expected to meet in Jamaica to discuss the crisis in Haiti. They have invited officials from other countries, including America, Canada and France. Gangs control 80% of Port-au-Prince, Haiti's capital. In early March they took over critical buildings such as police stations and government offices, and attacked the airport. The most prominent gang leader said the aim was to topple Ariel Henry, the prime minister. He has ruled unelected since the assassination of Haiti's president in 2021 and is very unpopular.

The Caribbean leaders may add to the pressure on Mr Henry to resign. He is in Puerto Rico, unable to return safely to Haiti. His resignation could make way for a transition government and then, eventually, elections. But any peaceful solution relies on the arrival of a planned security mission. Kenya has agreed to lead the UN-authorised deployment but does not yet have enough money or soldiers as countries hesitate over committing troops. With or without Mr Henry, Haiti's path ahead is treacherous.

Photo: Reuters

Japan’s two-track economy

Japan’s economy grew by 0.4% in the last quarter of 2023, according to revised figures released on Monday. The initial estimates showed a 0.4% contraction, the second straight quarter of decline. That meant that Japan’s economy was technically in recession. Thanks to strong capital expenditure, the fresh numbers proved rosy enough to affirm that Japan was not. Nonetheless, consumption remained sluggish, casting doubt on the economy’s strength.

The real economy’s struggles stand in stark contrast with Japan’s stockmarkets, which are booming. Bumper corporate profits, a weak yen and rising shareholder returns have lured international investors back to Japan. The benchmark Nikkei stock index is up around 20% since the start of the year, breaking an all-time high set in 1989. For the economy to prosper as the stockmarket is doing, companies will need to raise wages enough to encourage growth in domestic demand.

Photo: Alamy

Who can buy a leading conservative British newspaper?

Should an entity backed by a foreign government have a controlling stake in one of Britain's most influential conservative newspapers? That question may soon be answered by Ofcom, Britain's media regulator. Monday is the deadline for the watchdog to provide a report to Lucy Frazer, the culture secretary, on the proposed purchase by RedBird IMI of Telegraph Media Group, the owner of the *Daily* and *Sunday Telegraph*.

The prospective buyer is a joint venture between RedBird Capital Partners, an American firm, and International Media Investments. That is the investment vehicle of Sheikh Mansour bin Zayed al-Nahyan, the vice-president of the United Arab Emirates. He is known to many Britons as the owner of Manchester City, a successful English football club. Ofcom's report will cover whether the deal poses a threat to free expression and to news impartiality. The *Telegraph* has run many articles critical of the sale, which is also opposed by a large number of Conservative MPs.

Photo: T. Charles Erickson

A media scandal on stage

“Succession” was a television show that dramatised a power struggle within a media empire. Its creator admitted that Rupert Murdoch’s real-life dynasty was an inspiration. Fans of the show, which ended last year, will probably enjoy “Corruption”, a play by J.T. Rogers. It is now playing at Lincoln Centre in New York.

The play focuses on a scandal at the *News of the World*, a now-closed British tabloid owned by Mr Murdoch. In 2011 it was revealed that journalists at the paper had hacked the phones of many prominent Britons. One victim was Tom Watson, then a Labour MP. “Corruption” dramatises Mr Watson’s efforts to take on Rebekah Brooks, a former editor at the *News of the World* who had become an executive in Mr Murdoch’s business. (Ms Brooks left her job owing to the scandal in 2011, but was acquitted of criminal charges and returned to work for Mr Murdoch in 2015.) A halo of screens hangs above the stage. That makes “Corruption” feel less like theatre and more like a Netflix series.

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

Monday: The Institutional Revolutionary Party ruled which country continuously from 1929 to 2000?

He who rejects change is the architect of decay.

Harold Wilson